POLITICAL PARTIES

PARTY AS DEMOCRATIC INTERMEDIARY → SECTION 29A REGISTRATION AND → RECOGNITION AND SYMBOL ARCHITECTURE → PARTY SYSTEM EVOLUTION, REGIONALISATION → INTERNAL DEMOCRACY, MEMBERSHIP, CANDIDATES → FINANCE AND THE ELECTORAL-BONDS

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure: the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation gB and all prior artifacts unchanged

00 STAGE 00 — PARTY AS DEMOCRATIC INTERMEDIARY, NOT CONSTITUTIONAL SOVEREIGN

PARTY AS DEMOCRATIC INTERMEDIARY, NOT CONSTITUTIONAL SOVEREIGN · ROOT QUESTION · HOW CAN PARTIES AGGREGATE CITIZENS AND GOVERN WITHOUT BECOMING · DEMOCRATIC FUNCTIONS REPRESENTATION · PROGRAMME CHOICE GOVERNMENT · LEGISLATIVE COORDINATION · LEGAL LOCATION ORIGINAL CONSTITUTION · NO COMPREHENSIVE PARTY CODE.

ROOT QUESTION

How can parties aggregate citizens and govern without becoming private constitutional sovereigns? → DEMOCRATIC FUNCTIONS representation → programme choice government

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• ROOT QUESTION • How can parties aggregate citizens and govern without becoming private constitutional sovereigns? • DEMOCRATIC FUNCTIONS representation	• programme choice government • legislative coordination • LEGAL LOCATION original Constitution: no comprehensive party code.	• Tenth Schedule: defection only. • RPA 1951: registration, contribution and disclosure fields. • Symbols Order 1968: recognition and symbol disputes.	• TENSION public democratic power <— Article 19(1)(c) associational autonomy. • MUST REMEMBER: Separate Section 29A registration, Symbols Order recognition, Tenth Schedule discipline, finance disclosure and candidate regulation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: MUST REMEMBER: Separate Section 29A registration, Symbols Order recognition, Tenth Schedule discipline, finance disclosure and candidate regulation.

01 STAGE 01 — SECTION 29A REGISTRATION AND ECI'S BOUNDED CANCELLATION POWER

SECTION 29A REGISTRATION AND ECI'S BOUNDED CANCELLATION POWER · SECTION 29A ASSOCIATION APPLIES TO ECI · ALLEGIANCE DECLARATION TO CONSTITUTION, SOCIALISM, SECULARISM, DEMOCRACY, SOVEREIGNTY, UNITY · RECOGNITION REGISTRATION CREATES STATUTORY PARTY STATUS · RECOGNITION FOLLOWS SYMBOLS ORDER PERFORMANCE CRITERIA · INDIAN NATIONAL CONGRESS V. INSTITUTE OF SOCIAL WELFARE (2002) · ECI HAS NO GENERAL REVIEW/DEREGISTRATION POWER · NARROW CANCELLATION SURVIVES FOR FRAUD, FOUNDATIONAL DISQUALIFICATION OR ANALOGOUS

SECTION 29A association applies to ECI — memorandum/rules — allegiance → declaration to Constitution, socialism, secularism, democracy, sovereignty, unity and integrity. → REGISTRATION != RECOGNITION registration creates statutory party status → recognition follows Symbols Order performance criteria. → Indian National Congress v. Institute of Social Welfare (2002)

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• SECTION 29A association applies to ECI — memorandum/rules — allegiance • declaration to Constitution, socialism, secularism, democracy, sovereignty, unity and integrity.	• REGISTRATION != RECOGNITION registration creates statutory party status • recognition follows Symbols Order performance criteria.	• Indian National Congress v. Institute of Social Welfare (2002) • ECI has no general review/deregistration power	• narrow cancellation survives for fraud, foundational disqualification or analogous grounds. • TRAP loss of recognition, symbol consequence and deregistration are different legal events.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP loss of recognition, symbol consequence and deregistration are different legal events.

02 STAGE 02 — RECOGNITION AND SYMBOL ARCHITECTURE WITHOUT FREEZING PARTY LISTS

RECOGNITION AND SYMBOL ARCHITECTURE WITHOUT FREEZING PARTY LISTS · SYMBOLS ORDER 1968 RECOGNISED NATIONAL PARTY · RECOGNISED STATE PARTY · REGISTERED-UNRECOGNISED PARTY · ANY ONE DATED ROUTE · 6% VALID VOTES IN FOUR OR MORE STATES + · 2% LOK SABHA SEATS FROM AT LEAST THREE STATES · STATE-PARTY RECOGNITION IN FOUR STATES.

SYMBOLS ORDER 1968 recognised National party	recognised State party	registered-unrecognised party.	
STATE: ANY ONE DATED ROUTE vote-plus-seat tests	3% or three Assembly seats	Lok Sabha ratio route	8% vote route.

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• SYMBOLS ORDER 1968 recognised National party • recognised State party • registered-unrecognised party. • NATIONAL: ANY ONE DATED ROUTE	• 6% valid votes in four or more States + four Lok Sabha seats • 2% Lok Sabha seats from at least three States • State-party recognition in four States. • STATE: ANY ONE DATED ROUTE vote-plus-seat tests	• 3% or three Assembly seats • Lok Sabha ratio route • 8% vote route. • PRIVILEGE reserved symbol and specified electoral facilities.	• CONTROL criteria are Order-based and re-verifiable; do not freeze the current party list.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CONTROL criteria are Order-based and re-verifiable; do not freeze the current party list.

03 STAGE 03 — PARTY SYSTEM EVOLUTION, REGIONALISATION AND COALITION FEDERALISM

PARTY SYSTEM EVOLUTION, REGIONALISATION AND COALITION FEDERALISM · 1952–1967 CONGRESS SYSTEM · 1967 FRAGMENTATION · 1977 ALTERNATION · 1989–2014 COALITION BARGAINING · 2014/2019 SINGLE-PARTY UNION MAJORITIES · COALITION-SUPPORTED UNION GOVERNMENT AFTER THE 2024 ELECTION · CONTINUED STRONG STATE-PARTY COMPETITION.

1952–1967 Congress system — 1967 fragmentation → 1977 alternation — 1989–2014 coalition bargaining → 2014/2019 single-party Union majorities → coalition-supported Union government after the 2024 election → continued strong State-party competition.

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• 1952–1967 Congress system — 1967 fragmentation • 1977 alternation — 1989–2014 coalition bargaining • 2014/2019 single-party Union majorities	• coalition-supported Union government after the 2024 election • continued strong State-party competition. • PARTY-SYSTEM TYPES one-party dominance	• two-party tendency • multi-party competition • coalition system.	• REGIONAL PARTIES identity representation + State autonomy + policy innovation • <— personalisation + fragmentation + bargaining cost. • 2022 GS-II centralisation/autonomy preference follows organisational position and power incentives, not a permanent ideological law.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: 2022 GS-II centralisation/autonomy preference follows organisational position and power incentives, not a permanent ideological law.

04 STAGE 04 — INTERNAL DEMOCRACY, MEMBERSHIP, CANDIDATES AND DYNASTIC CONTROL

INTERNAL DEMOCRACY, MEMBERSHIP, CANDIDATES AND DYNASTIC CONTROL · MEMBERSHIP PUBLISHED ELIGIBILITY · RELIABLE ROLL · NOTICE/HEARING FOR DISCIPLINE · LEADERSHIP PERIODIC ELECTION · REAL COMPETITION · TRANSPARENT COUNTING · STATE-UNIT VOICE.

MEMBERSHIP published eligibility → reliable roll → notice/hearing for discipline → appeal. → LEADERSHIP periodic election → real competition → transparent counting → State-unit voice. → CANDIDATES local consultation + published criteria + integrity + representativeness → <— dynasty + money + winnability + central nomination. → CURRENT GAP

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• MEMBERSHIP published eligibility → reliable roll → notice/hearing for discipline → appeal. • LEADERSHIP periodic election → real competition → transparent counting → State-unit voice.	• CANDIDATES local consultation + published criteria + integrity + representativeness • <— dynasty + money + winnability + central nomination.	• CURRENT GAP • ECI receives organisational particulars but no comprehensive statutory internal-democracy code exists.	• REFORM LIMIT minimum process safeguards must not authorise State selection of ideology or leaders. • MEMBERSHIP published eligibility → reliable roll → notice/hearing for discipline → appeal.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: REFORM LIMIT minimum process safeguards must not authorise State selection of ideology or leaders.

05 STAGE 05 — FINANCE AND THE ELECTORAL-BONDS CONSTITUTIONAL RESET

FINANCE AND THE ELECTORAL-BONDS CONSTITUTIONAL RESET · STATUTORY SPINE · RPA SECTION 29B · CONTRIBUTIONS SUBJECT TO FOREIGN-SOURCE PROHIBITION. · SECTION 29C · REPORT CONTRIBUTIONS EXCEEDING RS 20,000; TAX-RELIEF CONSEQUENCE. · FCRA 2010 · POLITICAL PARTIES CANNOT ACCEPT FOREIGN CONTRIBUTION.

STATUTORY SPINE → RPA Section 29B: contributions subject to foreign-source prohibition. → Section 29C: report contributions exceeding Rs 20,000; tax-relief consequence. → FCRA 2010: political parties cannot accept foreign contribution. → Association for Democratic Reforms v. Union of India (2024)

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• STATUTORY SPINE • RPA Section 29B: contributions subject to foreign-source prohibition. • Section 29C: report contributions exceeding Rs 20,000; tax-relief consequence. • FCRA 2010: political parties cannot accept foreign contribution.	• Association for Democratic Reforms v. Union of India (2024) • Electoral Bond Scheme and enabling anonymity/unlimited-corporate changes struck down • voter Article 19(1)(a) right to information protected; SBI–ECI disclosure ordered. • The verdict removed one opacity mechanism; it did not enact a complete finance code.	• CURRENT LAW: 5 SEPTEMBER 2026 • ADR, 2024 INSC 113, remains the controlling electoral-bonds judgment. • It invalidated the scheme and enabling amendments; it did not enact a complete replacement campaign-finance code. • CLOSE DISTINCTION: Do not convert the ECI's bounded registration/symbol powers into a	• general power to control internal democracy or deregister parties on the merits.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The verdict removed one opacity mechanism; it did not enact a complete finance code.

06 STAGE 06 — WHIPS, ANTI-DEFECTION AND PARTY-SYMBOL IDENTITY

WHIPS, ANTI-DEFECTION AND PARTY-SYMBOL IDENTITY · PARTY ORGANISATION MEMBERSHIP, LEADERSHIP AND CANDIDATE SELECTION. · LEGISLATURE PARTY MEMBERS OF THE HOUSE BELONGING TO THE · TENTH SCHEDULE VOLUNTARY GIVING UP · VOTE/ABSTENTION DIRECTION · PRESIDING-OFFICER DECISION. · SYMBOLS ORDER · ECI DECIDES RIVAL-FACTION SYMBOL/RECOGNITION QUESTIONS.

PARTY ORGANISATION membership, leadership and candidate selection.

LEGISLATURE PARTY members of the House belonging to the political party. → TENTH SCHEDULE voluntary giving up → vote/abstention direction

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• PARTY ORGANISATION membership, leadership and candidate selection. • LEGISLATURE PARTY members of the House belonging to the political party. • TENTH SCHEDULE voluntary giving up	• vote/abstention direction • presiding-officer decision. • SYMBOLS ORDER	• ECI decides rival-faction symbol/recognition questions. • Sadiq Ali v. Election Commission of India (1972): majority in organisational and legislative wings informs symbol identity. • TRAP symbol dispute, internal leadership, whip authorisation and defection are related but legally separate proceedings.	• vote/abstention direction

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP symbol dispute, internal leadership, whip authorisation and defection are related but legally separate proceedings.

07 STAGE 07 — CRIMINALISATION, DISCLOSURE AND NOTA LIMITS

CRIMINALISATION, DISCLOSURE AND NOTA LIMITS · UNION OF INDIA V. ASSOCIATION FOR DEMOCRATIC REFORMS (2002) · PUBLIC INTEREST FOUNDATION (2018): NO JUDICIALLY INVENTED PRE-CONVICTION BAN · RAMBABU SINGH THAKUR V. SUNIL ARORA (2020): PARTIES PUBLISH · LILY THOMAS V. UNION OF INDIA (2013): · SECTION 8(4) SHIELD INVALID; DISQUALIFICATION FOLLOWS CONVICTION. · A STAY OF CONVICTION DIFFERS FROM SUSPENSION OF SENTENCE. · LIMIT DUE PROCESS AND SPEEDY TRIALS MUST ACCOMPANY DISCLOSURE.

Union of India v.

Association for Democratic Reforms (2002) + PUCL (2003): candidate criminal, financial and educational disclosure protection. → Public Interest Foundation (2018): no judicially invented pre-conviction ban; wider publicity ordered. → Rambabu Singh Thakur v. Sunil Arora (2020): parties publish pending cases and qualification-based selection reasons.

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• Union of India v. • Association for Democratic Reforms (2002) + PUCL (2003): candidate criminal, financial and educational disclosure protects informed voting. • Public Interest Foundation (2018): no judicially invented pre-conviction ban; wider publicity ordered.	• Rambabu Singh Thakur v. Sunil Arora (2020) parties publish pending cases and qualification-based selection reasons. • Lily Thomas v. Union of India (2013) • Section 8(4) shield invalid; disqualification follows conviction.	• A stay of conviction differs from suspension of sentence. • LIMIT due process and speedy trials must accompany disclosure. • People's Union for Civil Liberties (2013)	• NOTA protects negative secret choice but does not trigger automatic re-poll.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Rambabu Singh Thakur v. Sunil Arora (2020) parties publish pending cases and qualification-based selection reasons.

08 STAGE 08 — DONATIONS, DISCLOSURE AND FOREIGN-SOURCE CONTROLS

DONATIONS, DISCLOSURE AND FOREIGN-SOURCE CONTROLS · SECTION 29B PERMISSION · COMPANY/TAX CONTROLS · FCRA FOREIGN-SOURCE PROHIBITION · SECTION 29C · CONTRIBUTIONS EXCEEDING RS 20,000 · TREASURER REPORT TO ECI BEFORE INCOME-TAX RETURN DUE DATE · NON-COMPLIANCE AFFECTS TAX RELIEF.

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
Section 29B permission — company/tax controls — FCRA foreign-source prohibition.	non-compliance affects tax relief.	audited party account	limit != Section 29C threshold lawful privacy != blanket donor anonymity.
Section 29C contributions exceeding Rs 20,000	TRACEABLE ROUTES banking channel	beneficial ownership.	
treasurer report to ECI before income-tax return due date	electoral trust	DO NOT CONFLATE party contribution reporting != candidate expenditure tax cash	

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• Section 29B permission — company/tax controls — FCRA foreign-source prohibition. • Section 29C contributions exceeding Rs 20,000 • treasurer report to ECI before income-tax return due date	• non-compliance affects tax relief. • TRACEABLE ROUTES banking channel • electoral trust	• audited party account • beneficial ownership. • DO NOT CONFLATE party contribution reporting != candidate expenditure tax cash	• limit != Section 29C threshold lawful privacy != blanket donor anonymity.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: DO NOT CONFLATE party contribution reporting != candidate expenditure tax cash limit != Section 29C threshold lawful privacy != blanket donor anonymity.

09 STAGE 09 — JUDGMENT CHAIN AND BOUNDED INSTITUTIONAL POWERS

JUDGMENT CHAIN AND BOUNDED INSTITUTIONAL POWERS · SADIQ ALI V. ELECTION COMMISSION OF INDIA (1972) · SYMBOL IDENTITY USES ORGANISATIONAL AND LEGISLATIVE SUPPORT · UNION OF INDIA V. ASSOCIATION FOR DEMOCRATIC REFORMS (2002) · CANDIDATE INFORMATION AND INFORMED VOTING. · PUCL (2003) · DISCLOSURE SAFEGUARDS SUSTAINED. · INSTITUTE OF SOCIAL WELFARE (2002)

Sadiq Ali v. Election Commission of India (1972) — symbol identity uses organisational and legislative → Union of India v. Association for Democratic Reforms (2002) → candidate information and informed voting. → PUCL (2003) — disclosure safeguards sustained. → Institute of Social Welfare (2002) — no general ECI deregistration power.

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• Sadiq Ali v. Election Commission of India (1972) — symbol identity uses organisational and legislative support • Union of India v. Association for Democratic Reforms (2002) • candidate information and informed voting.	• PUCL (2003) — disclosure safeguards sustained. • Institute of Social Welfare (2002) — no general ECI deregistration power. • Lily Thomas v. Union of India (2013) — Section 8(4) protection invalid.	• Public Interest Foundation (2018) — no court-created pre-conviction ban. • Rambabu Singh Thakur v. Sunil Arora (2020) — party publicity and selection reasons. • Association for Democratic Reforms v. Union of India (2024)	• electoral- bond anonymity struck down. • State the exact proposition; do not turn a direction or narrow exception into a general power. • People's Union for Civil Liberties (2013) — NOTA as negative secret choice.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: People's Union for Civil Liberties (2013) — NOTA as negative secret choice.

10 STAGE 10 — PYQ DEMAND DECODING AND EXECUTABLE ANSWER SPINE

PYQ DEMAND DECODING AND EXECUTABLE ANSWER SPINE · 2022 GS-II Q13 TEST CENTRALISATION/AUTONOMY PROPOSITION · INCENTIVES AND ORGANISATION · COALITION CHRONOLOGY · INSTITUTIONAL FEDERAL SAFEGUARDS · OTHER HIGH-YIELD DEMANDS INTERNAL DEMOCRACY · REGULATION AT EDGES/INTERIOR · FINANCE AFTER 2024 CRIMINALISATION

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
2022 GS-II Q13 test centralisation/autonomy proposition → incentives and organisation	regulation at edges/interior	fragmented oversight.	QUALITY CONTROL exact year/paper/marks/words
coalition chronology → counter-evidence → institutional federal safeguards → verdict.	finance after 2024 criminalisation	ANSWER METHOD opening thesis → correct legal source → mechanism → named evidence	no party-list padding
OTHER HIGH-YIELD DEMANDS internal democracy	coalition federalism	limitation/counter → proportionate reform → one-line verdict.	answer-specific compression.

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• 2022 GS-II Q13 test centralisation/autonomy proposition → incentives and organisation • coalition chronology → counter-evidence → institutional federal safeguards → verdict. • OTHER HIGH-YIELD DEMANDS internal democracy	• regulation at edges/interior • finance after 2024 criminalisation • coalition federalism	• fragmented oversight. • ANSWER METHOD opening thesis → correct legal source → mechanism → named evidence • limitation/counter → proportionate reform → one-line verdict.	• QUALITY CONTROL exact year/paper/marks/words • no party-list padding • answer-specific compression.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: coalition chronology → counter-evidence → institutional federal safeguards → verdict.

11 STAGE 11 — UPSC ANSWER SYNTHESIS AND REFORM BALANCE

UPSC ANSWER SYNTHESIS AND REFORM BALANCE · PRELIMS FIREWALL · 29A REGISTRATION · FREE SYMBOL RECOGNITION LOSS · LEGISLATURE PARTY · BONDS VERDICT · FINANCE CODE. · MAINS SPINE DEMOCRATIC ROLE · NOTA != re-poll

PRELIMS FIREWALL → 29A registration != recognition → reserved != free symbol recognition loss != deregistration → disclosure != disqualification → NOTA != re-poll

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• PRELIMS FIREWALL • 29A registration != recognition • reserved != free symbol recognition loss != deregistration • disclosure != disqualification • NOTA != re-poll	• party != legislature party • bonds verdict != finance code. • MAINS SPINE democratic role — segmented legal basis — party-system evolution • internal democracy — finance → criminalisation — whip/symbol interfaces • autonomy-transparency balance → reform.	• REFORM PACKAGE verified internal elections • candidate criteria • donation transparency independent audit • trial expedition • narrow deregistration amendment proportionate ECI power + judicial review.	• VERDICT regulate the party's public consequences while preserving its legitimate associational core. • LEGAL/SOURCE LIMIT: The 2024 electoral- bonds judgment remains controlling • recognition lists, party courts, officeholders and election-specific symbol concessions are not frozen.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT regulate the party's public consequences while preserving its legitimate associational core.

E EXTRA — SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · PART A — FEATURES OF THE INDIAN PARTY SYSTEM · PART B — RECOGNITION · NATIONAL VS STATE PARTIES · MULTI-PARTY SYSTEM — NATIONAL, STATE AND REGISTERED-UNRECOGNISED PARTIES OPERATE · AVOID UNVERIFIABLE GLOBAL SUPERLATIVES. · ONE-DOMINANT-PARTY SYSTEM — RAJNI KOTHARI'S "CONGRESS SYSTEM" (DECLINED POST-1967). · LACK OF CLEAR IDEOLOGY (EXCEPT BJP, CPI, CPM); PERSONALITY

OPTIONAL DOCTRINE / CASE

- PART A — FEATURES OF THE INDIAN PARTY SYSTEM
- PART B — RECOGNITION: NATIONAL vs STATE PARTIES
- Multi-party system — national, State and registered-unrecognised parties operate at multiple territorial scales
- avoid unverifiable global superlatives.

ADVANCED LIMIT

- One-dominant-party system — Rajni Kothari's "Congress system" (declined post-1967).
- Lack of clear ideology (except BJP, CPI, CPM); personality, cult ; parties based on religion/caste/language .
- Emergence of regional parties ; factions & defections ; lack of an effective Opposition .
- Reserved symbol ; one proposer for nomination; broadcast time on state media; access to electoral rolls.

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

- Star campaigners: recognised = 40 , registered-unrecognised = 20 (their travel not counted in candidate expenditure).
- NOT: Parties are registered under the Constitution — registered under Sec 29A, RPA 1951 (a statute).
- NOT: National-party status needs 6% votes in all states — 6% in any 4+ states + 4 LS seats (or the alternatives).
- NOT: Recognised & unrecognised parties get the same star campaigners — 40 vs 20 .

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels